



Most attractive brand in India

According to a TRA survey, Samsung is the most attractive brand in India, and Reliance Jio ranked fourth. <https://digit.in/jan19-37>



Duo at 1 billion

Google's video calling app, Duo, released alongside Allo, has reached 1 billion downloads on the Play Store. <https://digit.in/jan19-38>

Sony Alpha A9

The mirrorless speed demon

One after the other, Sony has cracked the formula for reliable image quality, high resolution and impressive film capture, and now, with the A9, they are treading the sports camera territory. It boasts of the capability of shooting up to 20 frames per second (RAW) and a focus system that the company claims is perfectly suited for wildlife and sports photographers. But does the A9 deliver on all those accounts?

Build and Design

The Sony A9 was the first Sony mirrorless camera to bring a radical design shift from the second generation A7 cameras. The company added a joystick for manoeuvring focus points (or zones) which adds a whole new level of convenience. The dial arrangement has also significantly improved, with the top left plate housing the drive modes and metering dial. On the right of the flash hot-shoe lies the mode dial. Both dials feature locks to prevent accidental changes. The record button has moved to the bottom right corner of the viewfinder, a spot where the thumb can reach very naturally. The grip on the Sony A9 is also deeper than that on the previous Sony mirrorless cameras, which is good for those who have larger hands.

On the right side of the grip, you will find a latch which when opened, reveals the dual SD Card slots. There is the presence of a rubber seal on the latch, ensuring the compartment stays water-tight. Beyond the easy controls, if you want to make things even easier, you could always just use the touchscreen for operating the camera.

Autofocus Performance

The AF system on the Sony A9 boasts of 693 focus points courtesy a new phase detect system. The AF system provides for 93 percent of the frame coverage. The focus system makes

60AF/AE calculations per second, making it a whole 25 percent faster than the Sony A7 Mark II. The AF System can either be set to function in zones of different sizes or individual AF points, which are also available in various sizes. Depending on what you're shooting, the AF system can also be tailored to emphasize on focus speed or accuracy. For the most part, the AF system manages to perform really well.

Shooting Performance

The A9 offers a decent balance between burst mode and autofocus, offering a maximum burst rate of 20 fps when using the electronic shutter. The mechanical shutter, unfortunately, has a top speed of 5fps. Additionally, shooting with the electronic shutter allows you to shoot as fast as 1/32000 of a second, but it isn't advisable to shoot at such high speeds, especially if the subject is lit with artificial light.

We shot over 3000 frames between the two challenging conditions and walked away with roughly 90 percent usable frames. The camera was loaded with a SanDisk Extreme Pro SDXC 32GB card in Slot 1 and a SanDisk Extreme Pro SDXC 64GB card in slot 2. After some 40 minutes of shoot-



FEATURE.....	84
PERFORMANCE.....	88
VALUE.....	72
DESIGN.....	80

ing at the maximum burst rate, the 32GB card was full and the camera did not switch over the second card. A roll-over option is missing from the camera menu.

While tracking subjects on the X-axis was good, we were also very impressed with the A9's ability to

track subjects moving at a considerable speed in the Z-axis.

Bottomline

The Sony A9 is a huge leap towards bridging the performance gap between the mirrorless and DSLR form-factors. The ergonomics are top notch and the button layout makes accessing all essential features a breeze. However, at an MRP of ₹3,34,990, it is hard to say that this is the best camera for everyone. However, this is the best camera for those who seek the combination of speed, accuracy and reliability in a portable package.

—Swapnil Mathur

SPECIFICATIONS

RESOLUTION: 24 Megapixel | ISO RANGE: 100-51200 (expandable to 204800) | IMAGE STABILISATION: Sensor shift, 5-axis | FOCUS POINTS: 693 | CONTINUOUS DRIVE: 20fps (electronic shutter) and 5fps (mechanical shutter) | VIDEO: 4K @ 30fps, 1080p @ 120fps | STORAGE: Dual SD Cards, 1 slot UHS compliant | WEATHER SEALING: Yes

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